

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Dr Nida Ismail

Address: 95 Sandy Lane Cheam SM2 7EP

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: Dear Planning Officer,

I am writing as a local resident of Sandy Lane, Cheam, and as a practising GP, to express my wholehearted support for planning application DM2025/01591. I am particularly pleased to see a proposal of this kind come forward in our neighbourhood, and I hope the Council will give it the positive decision it clearly merits.

The case for community facilities in Belmont

Belmont is a predominantly residential ward that would benefit greatly from improved community infrastructure. The former ambulance station on Dorset Road has lain vacant since the NHS declared it surplus to requirements, and it represents a significant missed opportunity in the heart of our neighbourhood. This application proposes to transform it into a mixed-use Community Hub and Place of Worship, a use that will serve residents of all backgrounds with educational, social, and health and wellbeing activities, alongside faith provision for the local Muslim community.

The proposed plan fits in squarely with the objective of both the National Planning Policy Framework Sutton's own Local Plan. This is not a marginal or speculative use. It is what planning policy is designed to encourage.

A public health perspective

As a GP, I see the consequences of social isolation, poor mental health, and limited community

access in my patients every day. The evidence linking community participation to improved health outcomes is well established and is reflected in NHS England's emphasis on social prescribing as a frontline intervention. Loneliness and social isolation are recognised risk factors for cardiovascular disease, depression, cognitive decline, and premature mortality, particularly among elderly residents, new mothers, and those from minority ethnic communities who may face additional barriers to accessing mainstream services.

This proposal directly addresses those barriers. A permanent, locally-accessible community hub offering wellbeing sessions, educational programmes, social drop-ins, and family activities is exactly the kind of preventative infrastructure that reduces demand on GP surgeries, A&E departments, and mental health services. From a public health standpoint, this facility will benefit the health and wellbeing of Belmont's residents, and I would urge the planning authority to give this weight in its decision.

The particular value of this facility for women, families, and elderly residents

I want to draw the planning officer's attention to an aspect of this proposal that deserves specific recognition: the application explicitly proposes dedicated facilities for women, elderly residents, and families. As a woman and a mother living locally, I know first-hand how limited the accessible, safe, and faith-appropriate community provision is in this area. Many women, particularly those who are elderly, who have young children, or who do not drive, are effectively excluded from community and faith participation because no suitable local facility exists. This proposal directly addresses that exclusion.

In my clinical experience, women from faith communities who lack accessible local provision are disproportionately affected by isolation and its health consequences. Providing a permanent, welcoming, locally-accessible space for women's groups, family activities, and wellbeing sessions is a real social benefit that will improve quality of life for some of the most under-served residents in the borough.

The site is ideal and the design is appropriate

The former ambulance station is a brownfield site: previously developed, currently vacant, and confirmed surplus to NHS requirements. Its reuse for community benefit, rather than residential or commercial development, is something to be welcomed. The NPPF and London Plan strongly support the productive reuse of previously developed land, and this proposal delivers that alongside a clear community benefit.

The proposed physical works are modest and carefully considered: a part one, part two storey extension to the front and side of the existing building, a limited height increase to improve internal functionality, new cycle and refuse stores, and external greening. The design has been prepared sensitively, with no new upper-floor additions that would affect privacy or outlook for neighbours. The application also delivers Biodiversity Net Gain improvements and a full package of environmental assessments, demonstrating that the project has been properly thought through.

Transport, parking, and noise

I have read the Transport Statement and the Environmental Noise Survey submitted with this application and I am satisfied that both parking capacity and noise impact have been properly assessed. The Transport Statement demonstrates that on-street parking in the surrounding area has sufficient spare capacity to absorb the modest additional demand, and that Friday prayer times do not overlap with the school run at Avenue Primary Academy. The noise assessment confirms that the proposed use will not exceed background noise levels at neighbouring properties and will be quieter than the former 24-hour ambulance station. I do not consider it necessary to repeat the detailed figures here, as the submitted reports speak for themselves, but I am content that the concerns raised by some objectors on these grounds are not supported by the evidence.

I would also respectfully note that I expect the Council to assess this application on its planning merits, as I am sure it will. The proposed use is clearly policy-supported, the technical evidence addresses the concerns that have been raised, and the community benefit is substantial.

Conclusion

This is a thoughtfully prepared, clearly needed, and strongly policy-supported application. It will bring lasting benefit to Belmont, provide a welcoming space for women, families, and elderly residents who currently lack accessible local provision, and transform a vacant brownfield site into a real community asset. As both a local resident and a GP, I can attest to the pressing need for this facility and the positive impact it will have on the health and wellbeing of our community. I urge the London Borough of Sutton to grant planning permission for DM2025/01591.

Yours faithfully,

Nida Ismail

95 Sandy Lane, Sutton, SM2 7EP